

June 6, 2025

Block Voting in Charlottesville

How winner-take-all elections warp city politics across Virginia

In 2025, Charlottesville is holding its first ranked choice election — the most significant change to the city's electoral system in more than a century.

Some of the changes are obvious. Ranked choice ballots let voters share how they feel about all the candidates, allowing residents to express more nuanced views.

But ranked choice voting doesn't just change how we fill out our ballots — it changes who can run, who can win, and who can really have a voice in city government. This piece is the first in a series exploring the historic roots of Charlottesville's old block voting system, used in cities across the country to suppress diversity in local leadership.

For decades, civil rights advocates in Charlottesville have tried to reform the block vote and secure fair representation for city residents. The modern ranked choice movement builds on their work, offering a new path to the inclusive elections they have long fought to achieve.

How Block Voting Works

The basic [structure](#) of Charlottesville's City Council has been stable for decades. The Council has five members, and each

Learn More



Plurality
block voting
vs.
proportional
ranked
choice
voting

[FairVote](#) →

RankedChoice
virginia

Subscribe to our
newsletter to get
updates delivered to you.

Your email

member is elected to a four-year term. The terms are staggered in two groups, with two seats elected alongside the governor, as in 2025, and three seats elected in state senate years. All of the seats are elected "at-large" so that each member represents the whole city.

Prior to this year, Charlottesville chose City Council members using a [block voting](#) system, in which each voter could support as many candidates as there were seats up for election. In 2023, for example, when there were three open seats, voters could support up to three candidates, and the three people with the most votes won.

Member City Council at Large	
Vote for not more than three	
☐	Natalie E. Oschrin
☐	Michael K. Payne
☐	J. Lloyd Snook, III
☐	Dashad L. Cooper
☐	Robert F. Fenwick, Jr.

The block voting ballot for the Democratic Primary for Charlottesville City Council in 2023.

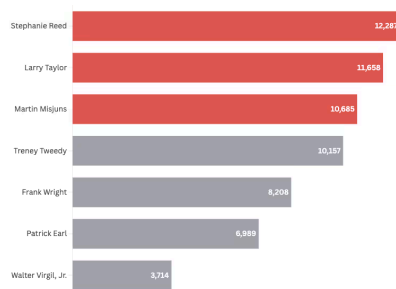
Though block voting sounds simple, it also quietly gives some voters all the power. If voters in the largest demographic or political group tend to support the same candidates, that group (or "block") will pick all three winners, leaving other parts of the community with no representation at all.

The winner-take-all effects of block voting are easy to see in recent partisan elections near Charlottesville. In Harrisonburg's last election, Democrats were 59% of the [Congressional vote](#), but Democratic candidates won all three [city council](#) seats because most Democratic voters supported the same three candidates. Republican and independent voters won no seats — despite being more than 40% of the voters and concentrating all their support behind one candidate.



Results from the 2024 election for Harrisonburg City Council. Javier Calleja ran as an independent candidate who appealed to Republican voters.

In Lynchburg, the partisan tables are turned. Republicans are typically a slim majority of Lynchburg voters — less than 55% in [Congressional races](#) — but Republican candidates won all the at-large seats on [city council](#) in their last election. Democrats and independents were nearly half the voters, but they won no seats because no one candidate could match the Republican block. In both cities, block voting allowed a modest majority of voters to capture all the seats in an election.



Results from the 2022 election for Lynchburg City Council. Tweedy, Wright, and Earl ran as independent candidates who appealed to Democratic voters.

While partisan examples make winner-take-all patterns easy to see, voting blocks can form around other features that divide the electorate – like race, age, wealth, and region – even in primary elections for a single party. If white residents are the largest voting block, racial minorities tend to be [underrepresented](#) among the winning candidates – even relative to their share of the voters. If most voters are [homeowners](#), then renters tend to be underrepresented, too. Over time, as minority voters realize the system is stacked against them, they may be less likely to vote in elections at all, depressing voter turnout and creating the illusion of consensus among the voters who remain engaged. In winner-take-all elections, the losing team has little incentive to play the game at all.

But Charlottesville's winner-take-all system wasn't inevitable — it was engineered. Learn [why block voting spread](#) across Virginia and the country in the second installment of this series.

← All News

Next Post →



Ranked choice voting is a small change to ballots that makes a big difference for democracy. Together, we can bring it to Virginia.

Learn More

About Ranked Choice

About Us

Local Action

State Action

Contact

✉ hello@rankedchoiceva.org

📍 703 Concord Avenue
Charlottesville, VA 22903

Subscribe To Our Newsletter

We don't email often, just occasional, actionable news. Explore our [recent updates](#).

Subscribe

© Ranked Choice Virginia. All Rights Reserved.